Singing Truth to Power: Musical Skits, Digital Performance, and Political Accountability in Nigeria's Media Society

Ph.D. Jude Ndubuisi Nwabuokei

Abstract

As Nigeria prepares for the 2027 General Elections, digital media have become increasingly important sites for political participation and democratic accountability. Among the most influential yet underexplored forms of online political expression are short musical skits and satirical performances disseminated across platforms such as TikTok, Instagram, Facebook, X, and YouTube. This paper argues that such performances constitute an emergent form of participatory political communication, enabling ordinary citizens, comedians, musicians, and digital creators to scrutinise political actors, expose governance failures, and influence public discourse in ways that often rival conventional news media. The study's theoretical orientation draws on participatory culture (Henry Jenkins), affective publics (Zizi Papacharissi), and performance as political communication; it examines how musical skits function as alternative media within Nigeria's digital public sphere. Methodologically, this study uses qualitative digital ethnography and multimodal discourse analysis of selected viral political performances produced before the 2027 elections; the paper investigates how rhythm, lyrical composition, satire, visual symbolism, and platform affordances combine to construct narratives of accountability, mobilise civic engagement, and shape political consciousness. It pays particular attention to how these performances circulate across multiple social media ecosystems and how they generate public debate, challenge official narratives, and sustain political memory beyond the news cycle. The study contends that short musical performances represent more than entertainment; they are emerging forms of digital civic intervention that blur the boundaries between journalism, artistic expression, and political activism. In a society increasingly characterised by declining trust in traditional institutions and growing digital participation, these performances provide netizens with innovative spaces for scrutinising political leadership, contesting official narratives and negotiating the meaning of political accountability.

Keywords: Musical skits, Digital performance, Political Satire, Political Accountability, Digital Media, Media and Society

Introduction

Digital platforms increasingly shape Nigeria's political communication environment, where citizens encounter, interpret, and respond to political issues. While conventional news media remain important to electoral communication and public accountability, social media have expanded the range of actors and expressive forms through which political discourse is produced and circulated (Jacobs, 2016; Bruns et al., 2026). TikTok, Instagram, Facebook, X, and YouTube have enabled comedians, musicians, skit makers, and other digital creators to participate in political conversation alongside journalists, politicians, and established media organisations. Within this expanding digital public sphere, short musical and satirical performances have emerged as particularly accessible ways to translate political concerns into humour, parody, music and performance. Such content complicates conventional distinctions between entertainment and political communication because performances produced primarily for popular consumption can simultaneously comment on political leadership, governance failures and the conduct of public officials. Thus, this article argues that political commentary in Nigeria's media society increasingly takes culturally familiar, entertaining forms. The study examines these performances as an emergent form of participatory political communication and asks how their aesthetic and platform-specific characteristics enable political critique to circulate beyond conventional journalistic spaces. It contends that musical and satirical skits create an alternative

communicative space in which political dissatisfaction can be rendered visible, emotionally resonant and culturally intelligible. Through rhythm, lyrics, parody, characterisation, gesture and visual symbolism, creators can transform complex political grievances into performances that audiences can watch, interpret, comment upon and share (Rose, 2025; Garg & Rai, 2025).

This circulation can extend political discussion beyond the immediate performance and allow particular political narratives, jokes, and criticisms to gain persistence within popular digital culture. Such performances raise an important question for scholarship on digital political communication: It draws on Henry Jenkins's concept of participatory culture, Zizi Papacharissi's theorisation of affective publics, and scholarship on performance as political communication, conceptualising these performances as affective participatory interventions. It examines how musical skits combine participatory and affective dimensions with platform circulation to produce alternative forms of political visibility and accountability. Through a qualitative multimodal analysis of selected digital performances, including the Facebook videos that form the article's primary empirical corpus, the study considers how music and performance mediate political criticism and how audiences are incorporated into its circulation.

The research questions that animate this study ask: how do Nigerian musical skits use music, humour, parody and multimodal performance to construct political critique and narratives of accountability? It also examines how social media platforms facilitate the circulation, visibility and audience engagement of these political performances. Together, these questions enable the study to examine both the representational strategies through which political meanings are constructed and the digital infrastructures through which those meanings acquire visibility, circulate across networked publics, and generate engagement. This dual focus positions musical skits simultaneously as multimodal cultural performances and as digitally mediated forms of political communication within Nigeria's evolving digital public sphere

Thesis and Argument

Nigerian musical and satirical skits constitute an emergent form of participatory political communication in which humour, music, performance, and platform affordances transform political dissatisfaction into affectively charged and highly shareable forms of civic discourse (Ajaegbu & Ajaegbu, 2024; Toumaras, 2025). This argument challenges conventional distinctions between political communication and entertainment by recognising that political critique need not occur exclusively through journalism, electoral campaigns or explicitly political speech. Within Nigeria's increasingly platformised media environment, comedians, musicians and digital creators can enter political discourse through cultural forms that are simultaneously entertaining and politically expressive. Musical skits can therefore expose contradictions in political leadership, ridicule official narratives and articulate popular grievances while remaining accessible to audiences who may not ordinarily engage with conventional political content. The political significance of these performances lies not simply in what they communicate, but in how political meanings are produced, experienced and circulated. Humour can make political authority available for ridicule; music introduces rhythm, repetition, and emotional intensity; and performance enables political figures and behaviours to be impersonated, exaggerated, and reimagined (Rai, 2015; Salukvadze, 2026).

Once disseminated through social media, these performances become potentially participatory texts whose meanings can be extended through commenting, sharing, remixing and response. The audience is consequently not merely a consumer of political messages but can become part of the process through which political meanings acquire visibility and circulation. Nevertheless, one should avoid equating participation or virality with political efficacy. A widely circulated skit does not necessarily produce political mobilisation, alter voting behaviour or generate institutional accountability. Its democratic significance is better understood through its capacity to make political critique memorable, affective, participatory and publicly discussable.

This distinction matters because digital political satire operates within commercial platforms structured around attention, engagement and visibility. The same affordances that enable creators to challenge political narratives can also encourage prioritising humour, spectacle, and emotional intensity. Digital satire consequently occupies a productive but contested space between civic intervention and entertainment, political critique and commodification, and participation and platform dependency. The article therefore conceptualises Nigerian musical and satirical skits as affective participatory interventions: cultural performances that make political critique emotionally resonant, publicly visible, and capable of networked circulation. Their significance lies not in virality alone, but in how performance and platformed participation create alternative spaces for political interpretation, public discussion, and accountability discourse.

Social Media and Nigerian Political Communication

The expansion of social media has fundamentally altered the communicative environment within which Nigerian politics is produced, circulated and contested. Political communication, once mediated predominantly through newspapers, radio and television, now operates within a more decentralised and interactive digital ecology in which political parties, journalists, activists, influencers and ordinary citizens can participate in producing and circulating political discourse. Research on Nigeria's 2023 General Elections, for example, identifies Facebook, X, Instagram, TikTok and WhatsApp as important spaces for disseminating political messages, mobilising supporters, countering competing narratives and facilitating real-time audience engagement (Aideloje et al., 2024; Okon et al., 2025; Chukwu, 2025). This transformation, however, extends beyond substituting one set of communication channels for another. Social media alter the conditions under which political visibility, participation and public discourse are produced. This shift has encouraged a more participatory conception of political communication. Citizens can respond to political claims, produce counter-narratives and circulate interpretations without requiring access to institutional media organisations. Recent scholarship consequently identifies social media as creating more decentralised and interactive forms of civic engagement in Nigeria, while also acknowledging persistent limitations, including misinformation, digital exclusion and forms of online participation that do not necessarily translate into sustained civic action (Iloh et al., 2026; Onayinka et al., 2026).

This latter qualification matters: increased digital expression should not automatically be equated with democratic empowerment. Indeed, the apparent disjunction between high levels of online political activity and offline electoral participation during the 2023 elections demonstrates the limits of assuming a straightforward relationship between digital engagement and political action. The contemporary Nigerian digital political sphere should therefore be understood as simultaneously participatory, affective and contested. Social media provide opportunities for political actors and citizens to shape public agendas, but they also intensify emotional appeals, polarisation and competing claims to political legitimacy. In this unsettled communicative environment, musical skits and political satire take on new significance. Their importance lies not simply in providing another channel for political messages, but in introducing popular cultural performance as a mode of political expression. By combining entertainment with commentary, such performances can expand political discourse beyond conventional news formats and create alternative routes through which political grievances become visible, affectively experienced, and publicly circulated.

Participatory Culture

Henry Jenkins's concept of participatory culture provides an important starting point for understanding how digital audiences have moved beyond the conventional position of passive media consumption (Jenkins, 2006; Jenkins, Ito & boyd 2016). For Jenkins, participation is not reducible to the technical interactivity enabled by digital technologies; rather, it is a cultural practice through which people acquire the capacity and confidence to create, circulate and attach meaning to media (Jenkins, 2006). He distinguishes participation from

interactivity precisely because the latter describes a technological property, whereas participation describes a cultural relationship to media. Jenkins's formulation is particularly significant for political communication because it recognises civic engagement as one domain in which participatory culture can operate (Jenkins, Ito & boyd 2016). Participatory cultures are characterised by relatively low barriers to artistic expression and civic engagement, support for creating and sharing content, and a sense among participants that their contributions matter (Jenkins, 2006).

Applied to Nigeria's digital media environment, this framework shifts one's attention away from the political message as a finished product and towards the social processes through which political meaning is produced and circulated. A musical skit, for example, does not conclude its communicative life when its creator uploads it. Its subsequent trajectory may involve users commenting on its political implications, sharing it with their networks, reproducing its jokes, quoting its lyrics or catchphrases, creating responses and parodies, tagging other users, or incorporating elements of the original performance into new content. In this sense, the audience becomes part of the communicative infrastructure through which political discourse acquires visibility. Jenkins and his collaborators' later concept of spreadability is useful here because it replaces the relatively passive notion of distribution with a model of circulation in which audiences make active decisions about what content to pass along, how to frame it and which networks it should reach (Jenkins, Ford & Green 2013).

This perspective is particularly productive for understanding the political potential of entertainment. Participation does not necessarily require membership of a political organisation, attendance at a rally or direct engagement with formal political institutions. Within platformed environments, political participation can occur through apparently mundane cultural practices: sharing a satirical video, adding a political interpretation in the comments, reproducing a politician's caricature, or using a creator's catchphrase to comment on a subsequent political event. Such practices can be understood as forms of vernacular political expression, in which citizens appropriate popular cultural forms to interpret political realities (Papacharissi, 2015; Howard, 2011). The musical skit's significance therefore lies partly in its ability to lower the symbolic and cultural barriers separating political discourse from everyday entertainment.

However, Jenkins's participatory model requires critical qualification when transferred to the Nigerian platform environment. Participation should not be romanticised as an automatic redistribution of communicative power. The ability to produce or circulate content does not mean all participants have equal visibility, influence, or access to audiences. Platform algorithms, commercial incentives, moderation practices and unequal digital resources continue to structure whose contributions become visible and whose remain marginal (Gillespie, 2018; Noble, 2018). Indeed, Jenkins's later account of spreadability recognises that contemporary circulation involves a mixture of bottom-up and top-down forces rather than a simple displacement of institutional power by empowered users (Jenkins, Ford & Green 2013). The Nigerian context therefore requires understanding participation as enabled but also conditioned by platform infrastructures.

This qualification is crucial to the present study. The political significance of a musical skit cannot be inferred simply from the number of views, shares or comments it attracts. Nor should every act of sharing be interpreted as evidence of political commitment. A user may circulate a skit because it is humorous, because it expresses an existing frustration, because it is culturally recognisable, or because sharing it strengthens a social relationship. Political meaning may consequently emerge indirectly through practices whose immediate motivation is entertainment. The focus should be on how entertainment-oriented participation can create conditions in which political interpretations, emotions and criticisms are collectively produced and circulated. Furthermore, it complicates the conventional opposition between consumer and producer. In the context of Nigerian musical satire, the creator may produce the initial political performance, but audiences shape its subsequent cultural life. They can reinforce its interpretation, contest it, detach its language from the original context, or transform it into a reusable cultural reference. A catchphrase can become political shorthand; a

comic character can become a way to interpret real political actors; and a musical refrain can acquire meanings beyond the original performance. What circulates, therefore, is not simply a political message but a culturally adaptable resource for political interpretation (Jenkins, 1992; Jenkins, Ito & boyd 2016).

Participatory culture thus provides this article with more than a description of social-media engagement. It offers a way of reconceptualising political communication as a process of collective cultural production and circulation. Nigerian musical and satirical skits are significant precisely because they bring political discourse into forms of participation already embedded in everyday digital culture. This provides the conceptual bridge to the article's central concern with musical skits as affective and potentially consequential forms of digital civic intervention. Jenkins's framework is valuable here because it enables an examination of how audiences participate, what they do with political performances after encountering them, and the technological and cultural conditions under which those practices become forms of political communication. It provides the conceptual bridge to the article's central concern with musical skits as affective and potentially consequential forms of digital civic intervention.

Political Satire as Alternative Media

Political satire has a long intellectual and cultural lineage as a mode through which power can be questioned, mocked and rendered open to public scrutiny (Gray, Jones & Thompson 2009; Test 1991). By relying on irony, parody, exaggeration, humour and indirect expression, satire creates a communicative space in which political authority can be challenged without necessarily adopting the formal language of political journalism or institutional criticism (Day 2011). Its significance therefore lies in its ability to make political actors, institutions and practices available for reinterpretation and ridicule. In this sense, satire has historically operated as a form of alternative political communication, particularly where direct criticism may be constrained or where conventional media fail to capture the vernacular ways through which citizens experience political life (Hariman & Lucaites, 2007; Baym, 2015).

Digital platforms, however, alter the communicative conditions within which satire operates. In conventional performance contexts, the relationship might be understood relatively simply as performance audience: a satirical performance is produced and presented to an audience whose principal role is to watch, interpret and respond. Digital satire introduces a more complex and recursive structure: performance platform audience comments sharing remix renewed circulation. The platform therefore becomes part of the communicative process through which the meaning, visibility and subsequent life of the satirical performance are negotiated (Jenkins, Ford & Green 2013; Gillespie, 2018).

This distinction matters for understanding Nigerian musical and comedic skits. Once uploaded, a performance can acquire communicative trajectories beyond those anticipated by its creator. Audiences may comment upon its political implications, tag other users, reproduce its phrases, create responses, modify its audio or visual elements, or circulate it across different platforms. The audience consequently becomes implicated in the ongoing production and redistribution of political meaning. Satire becomes networked and recursive, rather than transmitted from performer to spectator (Jenkins, 2006; Baym, 2015). The political significance of this transformation should nevertheless not be equated automatically with democratic empowerment. Participation can expand the circulation of political critique while remaining shaped by platform algorithms, commercial incentives and unequal visibility (Noble, 2018; Gillespie, 2018). Digital satire is therefore best understood not simply as satire relocated online, but as a form of networked alternative media in which political critique can be continually reproduced, reframed and contested through participatory circulation (Jenkins, Ito & boyd 2016; Highfield, 2016).

Affect and Political Communication

The relationship between emotion and political communication is particularly important to understanding the circulation of digital satire. Rather than treating emotion as the opposite of rational political communication, this article treats affect as one means through which political communication acquires social force. (Papacharissi, 2014) Papacharissi's concept of affective publics is useful here because it highlights digitally networked publics that emerge and sustain themselves through shared feelings, expressions, and storytelling. (Papacharissi, 2014; Papacharissi, 2015) Affective publics do not necessarily form around stable political organisations or coherent ideological programmes; rather, they can materialise through the circulation of emotionally charged expressions that allow individuals to "feel their way" or "vibe" with political events and issues.

This perspective is particularly relevant to musical skits, where political meanings are rarely communicated through propositional argument alone. Humour, rhythm, gesture, facial expression, parody and repetition can generate amusement, anger, frustration, recognition, embarrassment, solidarity, cynicism or hope. These effects can make political commentary socially memorable and give audiences reasons to respond to, reproduce, or circulate particular performances. Papacharissi's work on networked storytelling similarly demonstrates how digital political communication can combine information, opinion and emotion, making their separation analytically less useful than approaches that recognise their hybridity (Papacharissi, 2012; Candon, 2016).

Affect can therefore be constitutive of the communicative process itself. A humorous performance may transform frustration into laughter; recognition may prompt a viewer to tag another person; anger may motivate commentary; solidarity may encourage sharing; and embarrassment may make a satirical representation particularly memorable. In this sense, affect can make political communication socially sticky: it gives users reasons to remain attentive to, respond to and circulate particular messages. However, effective circulation should not be equated automatically with political mobilisation or democratic change. A widely circulated performance may generate laughter without producing sustained political engagement. The analytical significance of affect lies in examining how particular feelings facilitate the movement of political meanings across networked publics. Digital musical satire can thus be understood as an effective form of political communication in which feeling becomes part of the infrastructure through which critique travels, connects audiences and acquires public visibility.

Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative multimodal digital analysis of selected digitally circulated Nigerian political performances; it examines how political meanings are constructed through the interaction of musical, visual, verbal and performative elements within digital environments. The approach draws on multimodal discourse analysis (MDA), a concept that investigates how multiple communicative codes construct meaning beyond language (Jones, 2012), while remaining attentive to the platform contexts through which performances are encountered, circulated, and discussed. The analysis focuses on selected political musical skits and satirical performances circulated on social media platforms, with particular attention to their use of lyrics, rhythm, humour, parody, gesture, costume, visual symbolism and characterisation. It also considers the digital contexts surrounding these performances, including audience comments, sharing practices and observable patterns of recirculation. These elements are examined not as separate communicative components but as interconnected resources through which political critique is produced and made meaningful.

The study therefore treats the performances as networked cultural texts whose significance extends beyond their original moment of production. Attention to circulation is particularly important because digital platforms allow audiences to respond to, reinterpret, reproduce and redistribute performances. The methodological objective is to examine how their multimodal and affective characteristics create possibilities

for political commentary, audience participation and public discussion. The selected performances are analysed comparatively to identify recurring patterns in the representation of political authority, governance, accountability and citizen experience. This approach enables the study to connect the formal characteristics of musical satire with the broader communicative conditions of Nigerian digital media, while recognising that visibility, circulation and participation remain shaped by the affordances and constraints of platforms themselves.

Empirical Analyses

The participatory possibilities of musical satire are particularly visible in the two Facebook performances examined in this study. The first skit, Skit 1 - Facebook video, features a reggae artist whose performance uses reggae's musical conventions to comment on President Bola Tinubu. The lyrics question aspects of the President's educational background, identity, wealth and age. These claims are presented through musical performance rather than conventional political commentary, transforming potentially complex and contentious political questions into an accessible, performative form. The post attracted 224 comments, sparking exchanges between users who supported the President, opposed him, or were drawn primarily by the performance's musical quality.

The comments demonstrate that participation extends beyond simply viewing the performance. One commenter describes the political leadership in highly critical terms, stating that:

"A criminal cartel hijacked the country's leadership and the masses are paying for it" (sic).

Another commenter, apparently defending the President, invokes the 2022 election campaign and argues that, despite previous criticism, Tinubu:

"floored all his opponents and the naysayers" and is now "globally recognised and respected" (sic).

The significance of these contrasting responses lies less in determining which position is correct than in demonstrating how the musical performance becomes a discursive object around which competing political interpretations are articulated. The skit therefore does not end when the song ends; its political meaning extends and is contested through the comment section.

The second performance by a musical artist called Big Lion (Skit 2), spelt as Biqlion, offers a somewhat different form of political musical intervention. Here, Biqlion uses song to enumerate the problems and anxieties Nigerians face, including insecurity, hunger, inadequate infrastructure, and limited access to basic amenities. The performance drew 196 comments, many praising both the musical quality and the political message. One commenter succinctly observes:

"Great music, great message, good job."

Another expresses admiration for the performer while simultaneously voicing concern about his safety:

"I love your courage...I am afraid if this guy will not send assassins for you...but really don't want to lose you please be careful somehow" (sic).

This latter response is particularly revealing because it demonstrates the affective complexity of political participation. Admiration, fear and concern coexist within a single response to the performance. The commenter's apparent reference to being "assassinated" indicates that political musical expression is perceived not merely as entertainment but as potentially consequential dissent. At the same time, the response constructs a relationship between performer and audience based on recognition and emotional attachment. Taken together, the two skits illustrate the recursive structure of digital political satire identified earlier: performance platform audience commentary contestation renewed circulation. Their comment sections function as spaces

in which political meanings are affirmed, challenged and emotionally negotiated. Importantly, the volume of comments should not itself be treated as evidence that the performances produced political mobilisation or changed political attitudes. Rather, the exchanges demonstrate a more specific form of participation: audiences use the performances as prompts for political expression, disagreement, affiliation and affective response. Musical satire thus becomes a participatory form of political communication, in which entertainment provides the cultural form through which political questions enter everyday digital conversation.

Analytical Framework

The analytical framework for this study develops five coding dimensions that bridge theory and the empirical analysis of Nigerian musical skits, grounding abstract concepts in the concrete practices visible in the two cases study performances. Firstly, political representation examines how politicians and state institutions are depicted, focusing on the symbolic and narrative strategies that frame, contest, or ridicule authority. In Skit 1, for example, the reggae performer's lyrical references to President Bola Tinubu's alleged lies about his education, identity, and wealth foreground satire as a mode of political scrutiny, while audience comments such as "A criminal cartel hijacked the country leadership..." reveal how viewers extend and reinterpret these representations.

Secondly, performance attends to multimodal features: music, rhythm, gesture, vocal style, parody through which it produces political meaning. Both skits rely heavily on musical form: Skit 1 uses reggae beats to animate political critique, while Skit 2 deploys a melodic lamentation to catalogue insecurity, hunger, and infrastructural decay. These aesthetic choices shape how audiences perceive and emotionally engage with political content.

Thirdly, affect analyses the emotional textures mobilised by the skits, recognising how humour, frustration, recognition, ridicule, or fear contribute to the social force of political commentary. The comments on Skit 2, including expressions of admiration ("Great music, great message") and fear ("...am afraid if this guy will not send assassins for you"), demonstrate how affective responses can amplify or complicate political interpretation.

Fourthly, platform circulation investigates how sharing, commenting, tagging, and cross platform movement shape the visibility and iterative reproduction of meaning. The 224 comments on Skit 1 and 196 on Skit 2 exemplify how audiences become active participants in the communicative process, transforming satire into a networked, recursive form of political discourse.

Finally, civic intervention examines how these skits facilitate accountability, awareness, critique, or political memory. Audience discussions about Nigeria's political future, concerns about dissent, and reflections on governance indicate that musical satire can create conditions for civic reflection even when motivated by entertainment. Together, these dimensions provide a coherent methodological structure for analysing how musical skits operate as culturally embedded, affectively charged, and digitally mediated forms of political communication.

Performing Political Accountability

Digital musical satire in Nigeria performs political accountability by transforming political critique into humorous, affective, and participatory practices that circulate widely across social platforms. Across the skits analysed, humour, performance, affect, circulation, and civic intervention converge to produce a distinctive communicative form that differs markedly from conventional political journalism. Rather than presenting political information through formal reporting, these skits make power laughable, emotionally resonant, and socially shareable, enabling audiences to participate in political discourse through everyday cultural engagement.

Humour is central to this process. Satire destabilises authority by reversing the symbolic order through which politicians ordinarily maintain seriousness, ceremony, and respectability (Gray, Jones & Thompson, 2009; Day, 2011). Characters such as Governor Amuneke (Kevinblak) exemplify this reversal: through exaggeration, caricature, and comic incompetence, Amuneke embodies the stereotypical Nigerian politician boastful, corrupt, and performatively inept. Skit 1 deploys similar mechanisms. The reggae performer mocks President Bola Tinubu by singing about alleged lies concerning his education, identity, and wealth. The humour lies in the juxtaposition of reggae's relaxed rhythm with accusations of political dishonesty, producing a comic incongruity that destabilises presidential seriousness. Audience comments extend this humour into explicit critique: "A criminal cartel hijacked the country leadership..." reframes the skit's satire as a broader indictment of governance. Laughter here becomes a civic resource, enabling critique that is emotionally accessible and socially distributed in ways conventional journalism rarely achieves (Hariman & Lucaites, 2007).

Music and performance intensify this political critique by transforming political information into affective experience. In Skit 1, rhythm and repetition embed political accusations within musical pleasure, allowing audiences to internalise critique through melody rather than argument. Tone, facial expression, gesture, and comic timing further shape the performance's emotional texture, making political meaning felt rather than merely understood (Auslander, 2008). Skit 2 operates through a different affective register: its plaintive melody and sombre tone evoke frustration, sorrow, and recognition of Nigeria's hardships. The singer's strained voice and expressive gestures communicate emotional burden, while lyrics listing insecurity, hunger, and infrastructural decay produce a shared affective landscape. Audience responses reflect this intensity, admiration ("Great music, great message") coexists with fear for the performer's safety ("...am afraid if this guy will not send assassins for you"), revealing how effective engagement can generate protective publics. Drawing on Papacharissi's concept of affective publics, these skits demonstrate how political issues become emotionally charged events: political issue aesthetic performance emotional response circulation (Papacharissi, 2014; Papacharissi, 2015).

Platform circulation further shapes how these skits perform accountability. The 224 comments on Skit 1 and 196 on Skit 2 illustrate how audiences become active participants in meaning making. Sharing, tagging, remixing, and cross platform movement turn satire into a recursive communicative process in which users continually reframe political critique. Platforms are not neutral channels; they are infrastructures that amplify certain voices, intensify affective responses, and enable dialogic exchanges that extend the life of the performance (Gillespie, 2018; Jenkins, Ford & Green, 2013). The comment threads reveal political disagreement, humour, fear, and speculation about Nigeria's future, demonstrating how circulation produces publics that are emotionally and politically invested.

Ultimately, these skits facilitate civic intervention by enabling informal forms of accountability, awareness, and political memory. Audience discussions about governance failures, concerns about dissent, and reflections on Nigeria's political direction indicate that musical satire can prompt civic reflection even when motivated by entertainment. This aligns with scholarship on everyday political engagement, which argues that informal media practices can contribute meaningfully to civic awareness and democratic critique (Highfield, 2016; Dahlgren, 2009). The skits do not necessarily mobilise political action, but they create conditions in which critique becomes visible, memorable, and collectively negotiated. Through humour, affect, performance, and circulation, digital musical satire becomes an alternative mode of political communication, one that renders authority laughable, makes political issues emotionally resonant, and invites audiences to participate in the ongoing production of political meaning.

Discussion of Findings

The findings reveal several tensions that complicate the democratic possibilities of digital musical satire. The

relationship between virality and political efficacy remains uncertain. A skit may attract hundreds of comments, shares, and cross platform circulation, yet such visibility does not necessarily translate into behavioural change or sustained civic engagement. As Jenkins and Shresthova argue elsewhere, participatory visibility can create "thin" forms of engagement that feel politically expressive without producing institutional impact (Tufekci, 2017). Virality may amplify critique, but it can also dissipate into fleeting affective attention.

Digital satire must also balance entertainment with political seriousness. Humour makes politics accessible, lowering the cognitive and emotional barriers to participation, yet it also risks trivialising complex issues. Scholars of political comedy note that satire can oscillate between critique and entertainment, producing what Baym elsewhere calls "discursive integration," where political information is blended with humour in ways that may obscure structural analysis (Jones, 2010). The skits analysed here demonstrate this tension: audiences laugh, comment, and share, but the comedic framing may soften the gravity of corruption, insecurity, or economic hardship. Furthermore, the skits reveal a tension between participation and algorithmic dependence. While creators appear autonomous, opaque platform logics shape their visibility. As Bucher notes, algorithms act as "sensory infrastructures" that determine what becomes perceptible online (Bucher, 2018). The circulation of Skit 1 and Skit 2 is therefore not solely a function of audience engagement but also of algorithmic amplification, ranking, and recommendation. Moreover, digital satire exists within the creator economy, producing a tension between civic intervention and monetisation. As Abidin's work on influencer cultures shows, creators often navigate commercial pressures alongside expressive or political goals (Abidin, 2018). Political critique may coexist with revenue generation, sponsorship, or platform incentives, complicating the authenticity or independence of civic messaging.

Finally, satire risks partisan appropriation. Political actors may court, co-opt, or weaponise popular creators to harness their visibility. As Marwick and Boyd argue, networked influence is vulnerable to strategic manipulation (Marwick & Boyd, 2011). The same affective publics that enable critique can also be mobilised for partisan ends. These tensions underscore that digital musical satire is neither inherently emancipatory nor trivial; it is a contested communicative form shaped by humour, affect, platforms, and political interests.

Conclusion

Political communication in Nigeria increasingly unfolds through cultural and entertainment forms, where citizens encounter political issues not only through news media but through music, humour, and everyday digital creativity. Musical and satirical skits exemplify this shift by transforming political critique into affective, participatory, and highly shareable performances that invite audiences to laugh, feel, debate, and reinterpret political authority. Their democratic significance lies in their capacity to create alternative spaces of visibility, interpretation, and accountability, spaces where political behaviour becomes open to scrutiny through vernacular, emotionally resonant modes of expression. As Nigeria approaches the 2027 elections, these skits offer an important lens for understanding how citizens may engage with political issues within an increasingly platformised electoral environment. Rather than predicting their impact, this article suggests that musical satire will remain a meaningful cultural interface through which Nigerians process, negotiate, and make sense of political life. The paper recommends greater scholarly and institutional attention to digital performance as an important component of Nigeria's evolving democratic communication ecology. Researchers, media organisations, and civic institutions should recognise musical skits and other forms of participatory digital expression not merely as entertainment but as significant spaces in which citizens interpret political events, contest official narratives, and negotiate accountability

References

1. Abidin, C. (2018). Internet celebrity: Understanding fame online. Emerald Publishing.

2. Aideloje, S., Sylvester, D., & Jacintha, A. (2024). The role of social media in voter mobilization in Nigeria's 2023 general elections'. Ayika: Journal of Environment and Politics in Africa. https://doi.org/10.69778/2664-3022/4.1/a3

3. Ajaegbu, O., & Ajaegbu, C. (2024). The new democratisation: social media impact on the political process in Sub-Saharan Africa. Frontiers in Communication. https://doi.org/10.3389/fcomm.2024.1394949

4. Auslander, P. (2008). Liveness: Performance in a mediatized culture (2nd ed.). Routledge.

5. Baym, G. (2005). The daily show: Discursive integration and the reinvention of political journalism. Political Communication, 22(3), 259-276.

6. Baym, N. K. (2015). Personal connections in the digital age (2nd ed.). Polity Press

7. Bruns, A., Enli, G., Larsson, A., Robinson, J. Y., Bosch, T., & Kasianenko, K. (2026). The Routledge Companion to Social Media and Politics. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315716299

8. Bucher, T. (2018). If... then: Algorithmic power and politics. Oxford University Press.

9. Candon, P. (2016). Digital publics: Re-defining 'the civic' and re-locating 'the political'. New Media & Society, 18, 2133-2138. https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444816652600

10. Chukwu, O. (2025). Impact of social media on political communication: A comparative review of 2015, 2019 and 2023 election campaigns in Nigeria. Journal of Management and Science. https://doi.org/10.26524/jms.15.20

11. Dahlgren, P. (2009). Media and political engagement: Citizens, communication, and democracy. Cambridge University Press.

12. Day, A. (2011). Satire and dissent: Interventions in contemporary political debate. Indiana University Press.

13. Garg, G., & Rai, S. (2025). More than a laugh: examining the role of parody songs on Indian political discourse. Comedy Studies. https://doi.org/10.1080/2040610x.2025.2590862

14. Gillespie, T. (2018). Custodians of the Internet: Platforms, content moderation, and the hidden decisions that shape social media. Yale University Press.

15. Gray, J., Jones, J. P., & Thompson, E. (Eds.). (2009). Satire TV: Politics and comedy in the post-network era. NYU Press.

16. Hariman, R., & Lucaites, J. L. (2007). No caption needed: Iconic photographs, public culture, and liberal democracy. University of Chicago Press.

17. Highfield, T. (2016). Social media and everyday politics. Polity Press.

18. Howard, R. G. (2011). Digital Jesus: The making of a new Christian fundamentalist community on the Internet. New York University Press.

19. Iloh, M.C., Saint, E.J., Maiwada, A.A., & Onyejelem, T. E. (2026). Social Media and Political Communication in the 2023 Campaign in Nigeria. BIRCI Journal. Vol. 9 (2), pp. 29-36

20. Jacobs, S., & Schillemans, T. (2016). Media and public accountability: Typology and exploration. Policy and Politics, 44, 23-40. https://doi.org/10.1332/030557315x14431855320366

21. Jenkins, H. (2006). Confronting the challenges of participatory culture: Media education for the 21st century. MacArthur Foundation.

22. Jenkins, H. (2012). Textual poachers: Television fans and participatory culture. Routledge. (2nd edition)

23. Jenkins, H., Ford, S., & Green, J. (2013). Spreadable media: Creating value and meaning in a networked culture. New York University Press.

24. Jenkins, H., Ito, M., & boyd, d. (2016). Participatory culture in a networked era: A conversation on youth, learning, commerce, and politics. Polity Press.

25. Jenkins, H., Puroshotma, R., Weigel, M., Clinton, K., & Robinson, A. J. (2006). Confronting the challenges of participatory culture: Media education for the 21st century. MacArthur Foundation.

26. Jones, J. P. (2010). Entertaining politics: Satiric television and political engagement (2nd ed.). Rowman & Littlefield.

27. Jones, R. H. (2012). Multimodal Discourse Analysis. The Encyclopedia of Applied Linguistics. https://doi.org/10.1002/9781405198431.wbeal0813

28. Marwick, A., & boyd, d. (2011). To see and be seen: Celebrity practice on Twitter. Convergence: The International

Journal of Research into New Media Technologies, 17 (2), 139-158.

29. Noble, S. U. (2018). Algorithms of oppression: How search engines reinforce racism. New York University Press.

30. Okon, E. A., Ojedor, D.-R. O., & Owolabi, B. O. (2025). The Role of Social Media in the 2023 Nigerian General Elections: An Analytical Appraisal of Selected Platforms. American Journal of Arts and Human Science. https://doi.org/10.54536/ajahs.v4i1.3226

31. Onayinka, T., Oluwasola, O., & Oyedele, O. (2026). Strategic Political Metamorphosis? Organised EndSARS Protest and the Online Obidient Movement as Mediated Political Activism Shaping Nigeria's Deliberative Democracy. Journal of Asian and African Studies, 61, 5013 - 5029. https://doi.org/10.1177/00219096261440544

32. Papacharissi, Z. (2012). Affective News and Networked Publics: The Rhythms of News Storytelling on #Egypt. Journal of Communication, 62, 266-282. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1460-2466.2012.01630.x

33. Papacharissi, Z. (2015). Affective publics: Sentiment, technology, and politics. Oxford University Press.

34. Rai, S. (2015). Political Performance: A Framework for Analysing Democratic Politics. Political Studies, 63, 1179-1197. https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-9248.12154

35. Rose, A. (2025). Digital comedy as democratic participation: reimagining public discourse through humour in India's digital age. The Voice of Creative Research, 7(3), 359-369.

36. Salukvadze, G. (2026). Digital World as a Theatre of War: Political Performativity and Digital Strategies under Authoritarianism. International Journal of Research Publication and Reviews, 7 (8), 1928- 1937. https://doi.org/10.55248/gengpi.07.0826.2510

37. Test, G. A. (1991). Satire: Spirit and art. University of South Florida Press.

38. Toumaras, N. (2025). Networked Hyperlocal Activists: Digital Democracy and Engagement in Sub-Saharan Africa. Social Media + Society, 11. https://doi.org/10.1177/20563051251345945

39. Tufekci, Z. (2017). Twitter and tear gas: The power and fragility of networked protest. Yale University Press.

40. Empirical Data Sources

41. Biqlion. (2026). It's time [Facebook reel]. Facebook. https://www.facebook.com/reel/851923714653071

42. Egbujo, U. (2026, July 26). DSS, you have to arrest this one... he says our president has no siblings, no school [Facebook reel]. Facebook. https://www.facebook.com/ugo.egbujo/videos/dssyou-have-to-arrest-this-one-he-says-our-president-has-no-siblings-no-school-m/1405